1 Memory Technologies on a Microcontroller

A microcontroller contains two fundamentally different kinds of on-chip memory, and every part of a C program can live in only one of them. The choice is dictated by three properties:

1. Whether the memory sits on the CPU's memory bus (so every byte or word has an address),
2. whether it can be written with an ordinary store instruction
3. whether it keeps its content at power-off.

1.1 SRAM, NOR Flash, and Block Devices

SRAM (static RAM) is **connected directly to the memory bus**:

1. every byte has an address and is read or written with a normal load or store
2. **Fast**: one access takes about one clock cycle
3. **Byte-writable** at any time,
4. **volatile**: at power-off its content is lost, and at power-on it is **undefined** (random bits, not zeros). SRAM is therefore the only place where anything that changes at run time can live: variables and the stack.

NOR flash is also on the memory bus, like a ROM:

1. Every word has an address and random-access reads are fast.
2. The CPU can therefore fetch instructions directly from it, which is called **execute-in-place (XIP)**: no copy is needed before running.
3. **Non-volatile**.
4. **Writing is not a store instruction**: a whole sector (a few KB) must first be **erased**, setting all its bits to 1, and then individual words are **programmed**, which can only turn bits from 1 to 0. Both operations take microseconds to milliseconds and go through a command sequence sent to the flash controller, so at run time NOR flash is effectively **read-only**.

NAND flash (SD cards, SSDs) and hard disks are **not** on the memory bus:

1. Accessed through a controller one block (page) at a time, typically 512 B to 4 KB, and a block has no CPU address.
2. The CPU can neither fetch instructions from it nor read a single variable: content must first be copied into RAM. This is why a desktop OS needs a **loader** that copies the executable from the SSD into RAM. A microcontroller has no loader: its program already sits in NOR flash, at the address it runs from.

Technology	On the bus?	Execute from it?	Write at run time?	Keeps data at power-off?
SRAM	yes	yes	yes, bytes	no (volatile)
NOR flash	yes	yes (XIP)	no (erase/program)	yes
NAND / disk	no (blocks)	no	through a driver	yes

1.2 Placement Rules for a C Program

These properties fix where each part of a C program goes:

Program element	Memory	Reason
Code	Flash	executed in place (XIP)
Constants (`const`, string literals)	Flash	never modified: read in place
Variables	RAM	modified at run time
Initialized variables (`int x = 5;`)	RAM at run time + Flash in the image	RAM is random at power-on: the initial value is stored in flash and copied into RAM by the startup code before `main()`

The Cortex-M3 address space, and the two memories populated on `mps2-an385` (FLASH at `0x0000_0000` and RAM at `0x2000_0000`, 4 MB each), are described in the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture. The linker script refers only to these two memories.

2 Linker Script and Image Layout

A **linker script** is a text file, passed to the linker with `-T`, that describes the memory layout of the target chip and how the program must be placed in it.

```
MEMORY
{
    FLASH (rx)  : ORIGIN = 0x00000000, LENGTH = 4M
    RAM   (rwx) : ORIGIN = 0x20000000, LENGTH = 4M
}

ENTRY(Reset_Handler)

_estack = ORIGIN(RAM) + LENGTH(RAM);
_Min_Stack_Size = 0x1000;
_Min_Heap_Size = 0x1000;

SECTIONS
{
    .isr_vector :
    {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        KEEP(*(.isr_vector))
        . = ALIGN(4);
    } > FLASH

    .text :
    {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        *(.text*)
        *(.rodata*)
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _etext = .;
    } > FLASH

    _sidata = LOADADDR(.data);

    .data :
    {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _sdata = .;
        *(.data*)
        . = ALIGN(4);
```

```
        _edata = .;
    } > RAM AT > FLASH

    .bss :
    {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _sbss = .;
        *(.bss*)
        *(COMMON)
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _ebss = .;
    } > RAM

    .heap :
    {
        . = ALIGN(8);
        PROVIDE( end = . );
        PROVIDE( _end = . );
        _heap_bottom = .;
        . = . + _Min_Heap_Size;
        _heap_top = .;
    } > RAM

    __StackLimit = _estack - _Min_Stack_Size;
    ASSERT(__StackLimit >= _heap_top, "region RAM overflowed: heap collides with the stack")
}
```

The linker alone only merges the sections of the object files and resolves symbols: it **does not know which memories the chip has** or where they are. The linker script supplies this information. Based on it, the linker:

- assigns a final address to every section and symbol;
- places each section in the right memory (code and constants in flash, variables in RAM);
- defines symbols that the startup code uses, such as section boundaries and the initial stack pointer;
- checks that everything fits in the available memory, failing the link otherwise.

On bare metal there is **no OS loader** to decide where the program goes. The image must already match the hardware: for example, the vector table must be at address `0x0`, and initialized data must be stored in flash and used in RAM. The linker script is what guarantees this.

Internally, a linker script is divided into four parts:

Part	Role
`MEMORY { ... }`	declares the available memory regions: name, start address (`ORIGIN`), size (`LENGTH`), attributes (`r` , `w` , `x`)

Part	Role
`SECTIONS { ... }`	builds the output sections from the input sections of the object files and assigns each one to a memory region
`ENTRY(...)`	names the symbol where execution starts; used by tools (debugger, QEMU), not by the CPU
Symbol assignments (`_estack = ...;`)	create named addresses that the code can use, such as the top of the stack or the bounds of `.data` and `.bss`

2.1 MEMORY: Regions and Size Checking

```
MEMORY
{
    FLASH (rx)  : ORIGIN = 0x00000000, LENGTH = 4M
    RAM   (rwx) : ORIGIN = 0x20000000, LENGTH = 4M
}

_estack = ORIGIN(RAM) + LENGTH(RAM);   /* = 0x20400000 */
```

Each line of `MEMORY` defines one memory region; the two regions correspond to the two populated memories of the Cortex-M3 memory map.

Field	Meaning	Example
Name	freely chosen identifier, not a keyword	`FLASH` , `RAM`
Attributes	allowed access: `r` read, `w` write, `x` execute	`(rx)` , `(rwx)`
`ORIGIN`	start address of the region	`0x00000000` , `0x20000000`
`LENGTH`	size of the region	`4M`

The linker uses `LENGTH` to verify that the program fits:

- if the content assigned to a region does not fit, the link fails (e.g. `region 'FLASH' overflowed by 28 bytes`) instead of producing an image that cannot work;
- flash must hold `text + data` as reported by `arm-none-eabi-size` : code and constants, plus the stored initial values of `.data` ;
- `.bss` needs no flash, since it has no stored content;
- example: with `text = 96` and `data = 32` , the minimum FLASH `LENGTH` is exactly 128.

`_estack`. Defined as `ORIGIN(RAM) + LENGTH(RAM)` = `0x20400000` , one byte past the last RAM byte. The stack starts there because on Cortex-M it grows **downwards**: starting at the top of RAM gives it the most room.

2.2 SECTIONS: Output Sections Built from Input Sections

Each object file (`.o`) produced by the compiler or assembler contains its own sections, called **input sections**: `.text` (code), `.rodata` (constants), `.data` , `.bss` . The linker merges them into the sections of the final ELF

file, called **output sections**. The `SECTIONS` block contains one definition per output section, always with the same format:

```
<output_section> :
{
    <rule>            /* which input sections to take, e.g. *(.text*) */
    <rule>            /* rules are applied in order                   */
    <symbol> = .;     /* optional: give a name to the current address */
} > <REGION>          /* memory region where the section is placed    */
```

The output sections defined in this linker script are:

Output section	Content	Region
`.isr_vector`	vector table: initial SP and handler addresses	FLASH, at `0x0`
`.text`	code and read-only data (`.rodata`: constants, string literals)	FLASH
`.data`	initialized global variables	RAM (initial values stored in FLASH)
`.bss`	global variables initialized to zero or not initialized	RAM (zeroed at boot, nothing stored)
`.heap`	space reserved for dynamic allocation (`malloc`)	RAM (only reserved, empty)

The first two, both placed in FLASH, are:

```
.isr_vector :
{
    . = ALIGN(4);
    KEEP(*(.isr_vector))
} > FLASH

.text :
{
    *(.text*)            /* code from every .o          */
    *(.rodata*)          /* constants, string literals  */
    _etext = .;
} > FLASH
```

Element	Meaning
`.text :`	name of the output section created in the final ELF
`*(.text*)`	from every input file (`*`), take every section whose name starts with `.text`
`*(.rodata*)`	same, for the read-only data of every input file
`KEEP(...)`	always keep these input sections, even with garbage collection enabled

Element	Meaning
`.`	**location counter**: the address where the linker is currently placing content
`. = ALIGN(4)`	round the location counter up to a multiple of 4
`_etext = .;`	define a symbol equal to the current address (here, the end of the code)
`> FLASH`	place the output section in the FLASH region

Three consequences follow from these rules:

- **Order of rules = order in memory**: inside `.text`, all the code comes first, then all the read-only data.
- `.rodata` **has no output section of its own**: it is folded into `.text`.
- `.isr_vector` **lands at** `0x0`: it is the first output section placed in FLASH, and `.text` follows right after it.

2.2.1 Run Address (VMA) and Load Address (LMA)

```
_sidata = LOADADDR(.data);
.data :
{
    _sdata = .;       /* start of .data in RAM */
    *(.data*)
    _edata = .;       /* end of .data in RAM   */
} > RAM AT > FLASH
```

Every output section has two addresses:

Address	Meaning	In the script
VMA (virtual memory address, *run address*)	where the program uses the section at run time	`> REGION`
LMA (load memory address)	where the section's bytes are stored in the image	`AT > REGION` (if omitted, LMA = VMA)

For most sections the two coincide; `.data` is the exception:

Section	VMA	LMA	Why
`.text`	FLASH	FLASH	code runs where it is stored (XIP)
`.data`	RAM	FLASH	variables are modified in RAM, but their initial values must survive power-off in flash

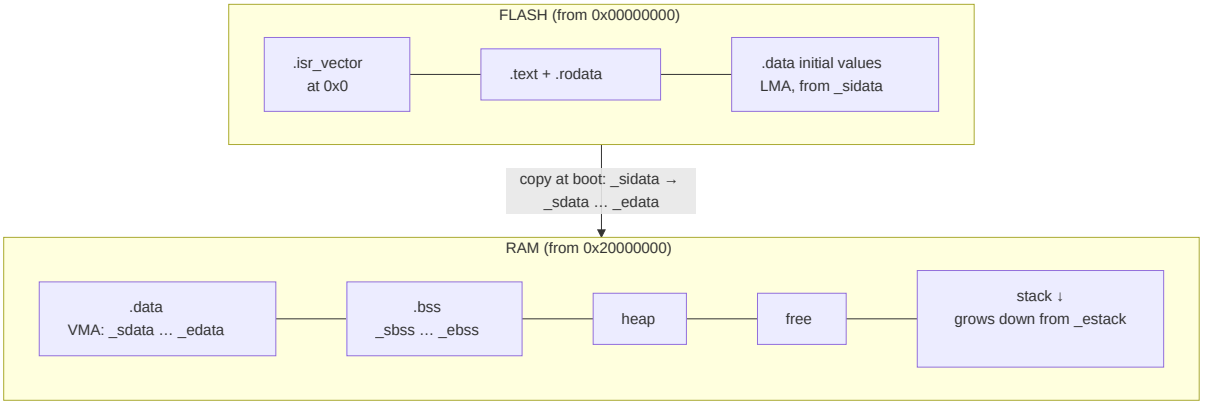
`> RAM AT > FLASH` means: VMA in RAM, LMA in FLASH. The script also records three addresses for the boot code:

Symbol	Value	Role in the copy
`_sidata`	`LOADADDR(.data)`: start of the initial values in FLASH (LMA)	source
`_sdata`	start of `.data` in RAM (VMA)	destination start
`_edata`	end of `.data` in RAM (VMA)	destination end

> **NOTHING COPIES LMA TO VMA AUTOMATICALLY**
>
> The linker only records the two addresses, and the CPU copies nothing at reset. The startup code must copy `.data` from `_sidata` to `_sdata` … `_edata` .

The resulting layout is:

Figure 3.1 — Load address (FLASH) and run address (RAM) of .data



2.2.2 .bss, Heap, and Stack Reservation

These three RAM areas occupy **no space in flash**: the image records only their size or bounds, never their bytes.

- `.bss` : storing zeros in flash would be wasteful, so only the size is recorded.
- `.heap` : it has no initial content at all; it is just space.
- **stack**: it is not even a section, only an address range below `_estack` .

```
.bss :
{
    _sbss = .;
    *(.bss*)
    *(COMMON)
    _ebss = .;
} > RAM

.heap :
{
    . = ALIGN(8);
    _heap_bottom = .;
    . = . + _Min_Heap_Size;
    _heap_top = .;
} > RAM

__StackLimit = _estack - _Min_Stack_Size;
ASSERT(__StackLimit >= _heap_top, "region RAM overflowed: heap collides with the stack")
```

Area	What it is	Bounds	Who prepares it
`.bss`	variables that start at zero	`_sbss` … `_ebss`	boot code fills it with zeros
`.heap`	space reserved for dynamic allocation (`malloc`)	`_heap_bottom` … `_heap_top` (4 KB)	nobody: it is only reserved
stack	**not a section**: the top 4 KB of RAM	`__StackLimit` … `_estack`	SP is set to `_estack` at boot

Element	Meaning
`*(COMMON)`	globals declared without a value (`int counter;`) that some compilers put in a "common" pool: they belong in `.bss` too
`. = . + _Min_Heap_Size`	advance the location counter by 4 KB, so nothing else can be placed there
`__StackLimit`	`_estack - _Min_Stack_Size` : the lowest address the stack may reach
`ASSERT(cond, msg)`	make the link fail with `msg` if `cond` is false

HEAP–STACK COLLISION CAUGHT AT LINK TIME

The `ASSERT` makes the **link fail** if the heap would run into the stack limit. A memory corruption that would appear at run time, and be very hard to debug, becomes a clear error at build time.

EXAMPLE

RAM `LENGTH = 8K` `_estack` moves to `0x20002000` and `__StackLimit` to `0x20001000` . The sections `.data` + `.bss` + `.heap` still fit inside 8 KB, so there is no region overflow. However, the 4 KB heap now crosses `__StackLimit` , and the link fails because of the `ASSERT` .

2.2.3 Linker-Defined Symbols

Symbols such as `_sdata` , `_edata` , `_sidata` , `_sbss` , `_ebss` and `_estack` have **no storage**: no memory cell holds their value. The linker only assigns each one an **address**, and the address itself is the information.

```
extern uint32_t _sdata, _edata;   /* "there is something at this address" */
uint32_t *start = &_sdata;        /* correct: the address (0x20000000)    */
uint32_t  oops  = _sdata;         /* wrong: reads RAM at that address     */
```

They are declared as `extern` objects only so that C allows taking their address with `&` . Reading `_sdata` itself would read whatever happens to be in RAM at `0x20000000` . In assembly, `ldr r0, =_sdata` means `r0 = &_sdata;` . The boot code uses these addresses as loop bounds.

2.2.4 Orphan Sections

GCC lets the programmer choose the input section of a variable or function explicitly:

```
int tagged __attribute__((section(".mysection"))) = 42;
```

If no rule in `SECTIONS` matches that section, it is an **orphan**. The linker still places it, guessing from its flags:

- writable and initialized → RAM, right after `.data`, with its own LMA in FLASH;
- read-only → FLASH.

> ⚠ **ORPHANS LINK SILENTLY BUT ESCAPE THE SCRIPT'S SYMBOLS**
>
> The link succeeds without warnings, but the orphan lies outside every range defined by the script. Here `tagged` lands exactly at `_edata`, so the copy loop over `_sdata` … `_edata` never initializes it: it reads 0 instead of 42.

2.3 Section Placement of C Declarations

Where a C declaration ends up in memory is decided in two steps:

1. the **compiler** chooses the *input section*, based on the kind of declaration;
2. the **linker script** decides which *memory region* that section goes to.

For declarations at file scope (global):

Global declaration	Section	Region
a function body	`.text`	FLASH
`const int k = 3;`	`.rodata`	FLASH
`"a string literal"`	`.rodata`	FLASH
`int x = 5;`	`.data`	RAM, initial value in FLASH
`int y;` or `int z = 0;`	`.bss`	RAM, zeroed at boot

2.3.1 Special Cases

Case	Where it goes	Why
`int z = 0;`	`.bss`	"starts at zero" is exactly what `.bss` guarantees: no reason to store the zero in flash
`const char *p = "hi";`	`"hi"` → `.rodata` (FLASH), `p` → `.data` (RAM)	two distinct objects: the characters are constant, the pointer is an initialized writable variable
local variable (`int local = 7;` inside a function)	**no section**: the stack	it exists only while the function runs and has no fixed address
`static` local (`static int s = 3;` inside a function)	`.data` (or `.bss`)	it keeps one fixed address for the whole run, like a global; only its name is private

> ⚠ **`const` POINTER VS POINTER TO `const`**
>
> In `const char *greeting = "hi";` the `const` applies to the **characters**, not to the pointer. The pointer can still be changed (`greeting = "other";`), so it is an initialized writable variable and goes to `.data` (`D`), while `"hi"` goes to `.rodata` . Only `const char * const greeting = "hi";` makes the pointer itself constant, placing it in `.rodata` (`R`) as well. Reading rule: start from the name and read leftwards: "greeting is a pointer to constant chars".

2.4 Inspecting the Linked Image

Three tools show what the linker actually produced: the map file, `nm` and `objdump` .

2.4.1 Map File

The **map file** (generated with the `-Map=` linker option) lists the *Memory Configuration* (the `MEMORY` regions) and the *Linker script and memory map*: every output section, every input section inside it with its source `.o` , every symbol's address, and the `load address` of `.data` . It also lists *Discarded input sections*.

2.4.2 nm: Listing Symbols

`arm-none-eabi-nm` is the GNU binutils tool that lists the **symbols** of an object file (`.o`) or of the final ELF image (`.axf`). A symbol is a name with an address: functions, global variables, linker-defined symbols such as `_sdata` .

For each symbol it prints:

- the **address**;
- a **letter** giving the kind of section the symbol belongs to;
- the **name**.

```
$ arm-none-eabi-nm -n build/scratch-os.axf
00000044 T limit
20000020 D counter
20000024 D greeting
20000028 B total
```

Letter	Meaning
`T` / `t`	code (`.text`)
`R`	read-only data (`.rodata`)
`D` / `d`	initialized data (`.data`)
`B`	zero-initialized data (`.bss`)
`W`	weak symbol
`A`	absolute symbol, belonging to no section

A lowercase letter means the symbol is local to its file: a `static` local `s` appears as `d s.0` , where the `.N`

`` suffix distinguishes static locals with the same name in different functions. The `-n` option sorts the symbols by address.

2.4.3 objdump: Section Headers and Raw Bytes

`arm-none-eabi-objdump` shows the content of an ELF file. Two options are used:

Option	Output
`-h`	one line per output section with size, VMA and LMA
`-s -j <section>`	the raw bytes of one section

For an image whose startup file contains only a two-word vector table, `objdump -h` shows `.isr_vector` at `0x0` (8 bytes), `.text` from `0x8`, no `.rodata` line (it is inside `.text`), and `.data` with VMA `0x20000000` and an LMA right after the code in flash, equal to `_sidata`.

Each line of an `-s` dump contains:

- the **address** of its first byte;
- **16 bytes**, in four groups of 4, in memory order;
- the same bytes shown as **text** on the right (`.` for non-printable bytes).

2.5 Worked Example

```
const int limit = 100;
int counter = 5;
int total;
int zero = 0;
const char *greeting = "hi";
char buffer[64];
```

Object	Section	`nm` in `main.o`	`nm` in final image
`limit`	`.rodata`	`R`	`T`
`counter`	`.data`	`D`	`D`
`total`	`.bss`	`B`	`B`
`zero`	`.bss`	`B`	`B`
`greeting`	`.data`	`D`	`D`
`buffer`	`.bss`	`B`	`B`
`"hi"`	`.rodata`	not listed (no name)	not listed

WHY `LIMIT` CHANGES FROM `R` TO `T`

`nm` classifies a symbol by the output section it ends up in. The linker script merges every `.rodata` into the `.text` output section, so in the final image `limit` is reported as `T`. The bytes are the same, in the same flash; only the name of the containing section changed.

The bytes of the image confirm the layout:

```
$ arm-none-eabi-objdump -s -j .text build/scratch-os.axf
 0038 00bffde7 4c000000 00000020 64000000  ....L...... d...
 0048 68690000 6d61696e 3a206865 6c6c6f20  hi..main: hello

$ arm-none-eabi-objdump -s -j .data build/scratch-os.axf
 20000020 05000000 48000000                    ....H...
```

Address	Bytes	Meaning
`0x44` (FLASH)	`64 00 00 00`	`limit` = 100 (`0x64`)
`0x48` (FLASH)	`68 69 00`	`"hi"` : `'h'` , `'i'` , terminating `'\0'`
`0x20000020` (RAM)	`05 00 00 00`	`counter` = 5
`0x20000024` (RAM)	`48 00 00 00`	`greeting` = `0x00000048`

LITTLE-ENDIAN

The Cortex-M3 stores the **lowest byte first**. The bytes `05 00 00 00` are therefore the number 5, and `48 00 00 00` the number `0x00000048` .

The last row is the key point: `greeting` holds `0x48` , which is exactly the flash address where `"hi"` starts. **A pointer is simply a variable whose value is an address.**

Variables in `.data` appear in definition order. In this example the first 32 bytes of `.data` (`0x20000000` – `0x2000001F`) hold a string defined earlier in the file, so `counter` and `greeting` follow at `0x20000020` and `0x20000024` .

3 Vector Table Placement and Section Garbage Collection

The vector table, described in the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture, is the first data the CPU reads after reset: word 0 becomes the initial main stack pointer and word 1 the address of `Reset_Handler`. Because `VTOR` resets to `0x0000_0000`, the table must sit at the very start of FLASH when the CPU leaves reset. The startup code therefore puts the table in its own input section, `.isr_vector`, and the linker script places that section first in FLASH, before `.text`. Each handler address is stored with bit 0 set (the Thumb bit), so with a 16-word table the first code starts at `0x40` and word 1 reads `0x41`.

> ⚠ **THE VECTOR TABLE IS IN FLASH, NOT RAM**
>
> At reset the table sits at address `0x0`, the start of the Code/FLASH region. RAM starts at `0x20000000` and holds only `.data`, `.bss`, heap, and stack. The table can be relocated later through `VTOR` (for example into RAM), but this is a deliberate software choice.

3.1 KEEP and Section Garbage Collection

With the option `-Wl,--gc-sections`, the linker performs **garbage collection of sections**:

1. it starts from the `ENTRY` symbol (`Reset_Handler`);
2. it follows every reference from one section to another (calls, pointers, addresses);
3. it **drops every input section that nothing references**.

This is useful to trim unused code, but it is dangerous for data that **only the hardware reads**. No code references the vector table: the CPU reads it by itself at reset. For the linker it is therefore unused, and it would be discarded.

`KEEP(*(.isr_vector))` marks those input sections as **always kept**, whatever the garbage collector decides.

`--gc-sections`	`KEEP`	Result
off	present or absent	nothing is collected: `KEEP` changes nothing, it only acts as insurance
on	present	`.isr_vector` is kept at `0x0`: the image works
on	absent	`.isr_vector` is discarded: the image does not boot

> ⚠ **WHAT HAPPENS WITHOUT `KEEP`**
>
> 1. `.isr_vector` shrinks to size 0; the map file lists it under *Discarded input sections*.
> 2. `.text` becomes the first section in FLASH, so `Reset_Handler` lands at `0x0`.
> 3. At reset the CPU reads the first two words at `0x0`, which are now **instructions**, and loads them as SP and PC.
> 4. With a meaningless SP and PC, execution faults immediately and the CPU ends in **lockup**.

4 The Startup Code: `boot/startup.s`

The **startup code** (`boot/startup.s`) is the first code the CPU executes after reset, before `main()`. It contains two parts:

- the **vector table**, from which the hardware loads the initial SP and PC;
- `Reset_Handler`, the function that prepares the machine to run C code.

```
// THE COMPLETE STARTUP CODE

/* Assembler settings */
    .syntax unified             /* modern ARM syntax */
    .cpu cortex-m3              /* only M3 instructions */
    .thumb                      /* Thumb code only */

/* 1. Vector table */
    .section .isr_vector,"a",%progbits
    .global isr_vector
    .type isr_vector, %object
isr_vector:
    .word _estack               /* 0: initial SP */
    .word Reset_Handler         /* 1: reset */
    .word NMI_Handler           /* 2: NMI */
    .word HardFault_Handler     /* 3: HardFault */
    .word MemManage_Handler     /* 4: MemManage */
    .word BusFault_Handler      /* 5: BusFault */
    .word UsageFault_Handler    /* 6: UsageFault */
    .word 0                     /* 7: reserved */
    .word 0                     /* 8: reserved */
    .word 0                     /* 9: reserved */
    .word 0                     /* 10: reserved */
    .word SVC_Handler           /* 11: SVCall */
    .word DebugMon_Handler      /* 12: debug monitor */
    .word 0                     /* 13: reserved */
    .word PendSV_Handler        /* 14: PendSV */
    .word SysTick_Handler       /* 15: SysTick */
    .size isr_vector, . - isr_vector

/* Default handlers: weak aliases of Default_Handler */
    .weak      NMI_Handler
    .thumb_set NMI_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      HardFault_Handler
    .thumb_set HardFault_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      MemManage_Handler
```

```
    .thumb_set MemManage_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      BusFault_Handler
    .thumb_set BusFault_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      UsageFault_Handler
    .thumb_set UsageFault_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      SVC_Handler
    .thumb_set SVC_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      DebugMon_Handler
    .thumb_set DebugMon_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      PendSV_Handler
    .thumb_set PendSV_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      SysTick_Handler
    .thumb_set SysTick_Handler, Default_Handler

/* 2. Reset_Handler */
    .section .text,"ax",%progbits
    .global Reset_Handler
    .type Reset_Handler, %function
    .thumb_func
Reset_Handler:

    /* Step 1: mask interrupts */
    cpsid i                     /* PRIMASK = 1 */

    /* Step 2: set SP */
    ldr r0, =_estack
    mov sp, r0

    /* Step 3: copy .data FLASH -> RAM */
    ldr r0, =_sidata            /* src */
    ldr r1, =_sdata             /* dst */
    ldr r2, =_edata             /* end */
copy_data:
    cmp r1, r2                  /* while (dst < end) */
    bhs copy_data_done
    ldr r3, [r0], #4            /* r3 = *src++ */
    str r3, [r1], #4            /* *dst++ = r3 */
    b copy_data
copy_data_done:

    /* Step 4: zero .bss */
    ldr r1, =_sbss              /* dst */
    ldr r2, =_ebss              /* end */
```

```
    movs r3, #0
zero_bss:
    cmp r1, r2                  /* while (dst < end) */
    bhs zero_bss_done
    str r3, [r1], #4            /* *dst++ = 0 */
    b zero_bss
zero_bss_done:

    /* Step 5: VTOR = &isr_vector */
    ldr r0, =0xE000ED08
    ldr r1, =isr_vector
    str r1, [r0]

    /* Step 6: SHCSR |= bits 16-18 */
    ldr r0, =0xE000ED24
    ldr r1, [r0]
    orr r1, r1, #0x00070000
    str r1, [r0]

    /* Step 7: CCR |= DIV_0_TRP */
    ldr r0, =0xE000ED14
    ldr r1, [r0]
    orr r1, r1, #(1 << 4)
    str r1, [r0]

    /* Step 8: priorities (SHPR1-3) */
    ldr r0, =0xE000ED18
    movs r1, #0x00
    strb r1, [r0, #0]           /* MemManage */
    strb r1, [r0, #1]           /* BusFault */
    strb r1, [r0, #2]           /* UsageFault */
    movs r1, #0x80
    strb r1, [r0, #7]           /* SVCall */
    movs r1, #0xE0
    strb r1, [r0, #10]          /* PendSV */
    strb r1, [r0, #11]          /* SysTick */

    /* Step 9: unmask interrupts */
    cpsie i                     /* PRIMASK = 0 */

    /* Step 10: call main, then hang */
    bl main
hang:
```

```
    b hang

    .ltorg                      /* literal pool */
    .size Reset_Handler, . - Reset_Handler

/* 3. Default_Handler */
    .global Default_Handler
    .type Default_Handler, %function
    .thumb_func
Default_Handler:
    b Default_Handler           /* for (;;) {} */
    .size Default_Handler, . - Default_Handler
```

The order of the steps is dictated by dependencies: nothing may interrupt a half-built system, C needs a stack, globals must hold their values before any C code reads them, and the configuration must be complete before interrupts are accepted.

Step	Action	Reason
1	mask interrupts (`cpsid i`)	nothing may interrupt a half-built system
2	set SP	C functions need a stack
3	copy `.data` FLASH → RAM	initialized globals get their values
4	zero `.bss`	C guarantees uninitialized globals start at 0
5–8	configure the CPU	vector table address, fault handlers, divide-by-zero trap, priorities
9	unmask interrupts (`cpsie i`)	setup is complete
10	`bl main` , then loop forever	hand over to C; on bare metal there is nothing to return to

It works in sequence:

1. **Hardware**: at reset the CPU loads SP from word 0 and PC from word 1 of the vector table, so execution starts at `Reset_Handler` .
2. **Stack**: `Reset_Handler` sets SP to `_estack` , the top of RAM.
3. **`.data`** : it copies the initial values of the initialized variables from FLASH (`_sidata`) to RAM (`_sdata` … `_edata`).
4. **`.bss`** : it fills `_sbss` … `_ebss` with zeros.
5. **CPU configuration**: it sets up the vector table address, fault handlers and priorities.
6. **`main()`** : it calls `main` and, if `main` ever returns, loops forever.

All the addresses used in steps 2–4 are symbols defined by the linker script (see the linker script section above). The two work at different times: the linker script is used only at **build time** to place sections and define those symbols, and it is never executed; the startup code runs on the CPU at **run time** and uses them as loop bounds. Each step is explained in the reset handler section below.

WHY ASSEMBLY

When the startup code begins, the stack has not been set up yet and `.data` and `.bss` are not initialized. C code takes all of these for granted, so it cannot be trusted until the startup code has finished. On a desktop this job is done by **crt0**, the C library's startup code; on bare metal it is excluded (`-nostartfiles`) and written by hand.

Writing the startup code needs only a small subset of Thumb instructions: loads and stores, constants and literal pools, labels, compares, and branches. They are summarised in the instruction table of the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture. The assembler directives, which steer the assembler rather than the CPU, are described below.

4.1 Assembler Directives

Lines starting with a dot produce no instructions; they steer the assembler.

```
    .section .isr_vector,"a",%progbits   @ following content goes into .isr_vector
    .global isr_vector                   @ name visible to the linker
isr_vector:
    .word _estack                        @ one 32-bit value
    .word Reset_Handler

    .section .text,"ax",%progbits
    .global Reset_Handler
    .thumb_func                          @ next label is Thumb code: bit 0 = 1
Reset_Handler:
```

The equivalent vector table in C is:

```
__attribute__((section(".isr_vector")))
const uint32_t isr_vector[] = { (uint32_t)&_estack, (uint32_t)Reset_Handler };
```

Directive	Effect
`.section name,"flags"`	selects the section; `a` = occupies space in the image, `x` = executable
`.global name`	exports the name to other files and the linker (otherwise it behaves like a `static` C name)
`.thumb_func`	marks the next label as Thumb code, so its address is stored with bit 0 set
`.word X`	stores the 32-bit value X
`.type` , `.size`	tell `nm` and gdb whether a name is code or data, and its size
`.weak name`	declares a weak symbol, overridable by a normal definition
`.thumb_set a, b`	makes `a` an alias of `b` , marked as Thumb code

Directive	Effect
`.ltorg`	emits the literal pool here

5 Reset Handler: From Reset to main()

`Reset_Handler` is the function the CPU executes **first** after every reset. Its address is **stored in slot 1 of the vector table**: at reset the hardware loads that word into PC, so execution starts here, before any C code.

On bare metal there is no operating system and no C library to prepare the machine. `Reset_Handler` takes their place: it brings the CPU and the memory into the state that C code assumes, configures how the CPU reacts to errors, and only then calls `main()`. Its work is organized in two jobs, carried out in order:

Job	Steps	Without it
Make C code safe to run	set the stack, copy `.data`, zero `.bss`	globals hold wrong values, function calls have no valid stack
Configure the CPU	vector table address, separate fault handlers, divide-by-zero trap, priorities	errors pass silently or all end up in the same HardFault

> **A STARTUP THAT ONLY CALLS `MAIN`**
>
> Consider a minimal `Reset_Handler` that executes only `bl main`, and a global `char data_message[] = "hello";`:
>
> - the linker places the bytes `"hello"` in **FLASH** (LMA) and reserves space for `data_message` in **RAM** (VMA);
> - nobody copies the bytes from FLASH to RAM;
> - `main` reads `data_message` from **RAM**, where the copy was never written.
>
> The result depends on what RAM contains at power-on. QEMU fills RAM with zeros, so the first byte is `'\0'` and the string reads as **empty**. Real hardware leaves random content, so the string reads as **garbage**. The program compiles and runs, but the data is wrong: this is the kind of silent error the copy loop prevents.

5.1 Weak Default Handlers

The vector table has 16 slots, and the CPU jumps to whatever address slot N contains when exception N occurs. Every slot must therefore point to valid code, even for exceptions the program does not handle yet; reserved slots simply hold `0`. Instead of writing nine real handlers, the startup code uses two pieces:

- **`Default_Handler`**: a single catch-all function, an infinite loop (`for (;;) {}`);
- **weak names**: every handler name in the table is declared `.weak` and, by default, is an alias of `Default_Handler` (same address).

A **weak** symbol is a default that gives way: if another file defines a normal (strong) function with the same name, the linker uses that one and drops the weak alias. A handler is installed simply by writing a C function with the right name, without touching the assembly. The C equivalent of each weak name is:

```
void HardFault_Handler(void) __attribute__((weak, alias("Default_Handler")));
```

With only `UsageFault_Handler` defined in `main.c`:

Slot	Name	Defined in C?	CPU jumps to	`nm`
3	`HardFault_Handler`	no	`Default_Handler`	`W`, same address as `Default_Handler`
6	`UsageFault_Handler`	yes	the C function	`T`, its own address
15	`SysTick_Handler`	no	`Default_Handler`	`W`, same address as `Default_Handler`

> **WHY AN INFINITE LOOP**
>
> An unexpected exception is a bug. Freezing at a known place lets a debugger show immediately that PC is in `Default_Handler`, instead of letting the CPU run off into random memory.

5.2 Interrupt Masking and Stack Setup

`cpsid i` sets **PRIMASK**, a 1-bit core register (not memory-mapped): while it is 1, every exception with configurable priority is ignored; only NMI and HardFault get through. Interrupts arriving while masked are not lost: they remain **pending** and run as soon as `cpsie i` clears PRIMASK. PRIMASK is 0 at reset; the boot code sets it first and clears it only after the vector table, handlers and priorities are in place.

Instruction	PRIMASK	C (vendor headers)
`cpsid i`	1: masked	`__disable_irq()`
`cpsie i`	0: accepted	`__enable_irq()`

SP is set explicitly even though the hardware already loaded it from vector word 0, because `Reset_Handler` is not always reached through a real reset: a bootloader or debugger may jump to it with SP holding any value. SP is a special register, so the address is first loaded into `r0` with `ldr` and then moved with `mov sp, r0`.

> **FAILURE MODES OF A WRONG SP**
>
> With SP = `0x30000000` (outside RAM), the first push in `main` writes to a non-existent address and faults; reporting the fault requires stacking registers, which faults again, and the CPU enters lockup. With SP = `0x20000001`, the CPU silently clears the two low bits (SP is always word-aligned), so the stack starts at the bottom of RAM and grows *below* it, into an unmapped range where QEMU ignores writes: every call fails silently and nothing is printed.

5.3 Initializing .data and .bss

The `.data` copy translates `while (dst < &_edata) *dst++ = *src++;` with `r0` = `src` (`_sidata`), `r1` = `dst` (`_sdata`) and `r2` = end (`_edata`). It copies whole words, which is safe because the linker script aligns the start and end of `.data` to 4 bytes. Stepping through the loop in a debugger shows `r1` climbing `0x20000000`, `0x20000004`, … until it equals `&_edata`; only then does the string appear in RAM.

The `.bss` loop has the same shape without a source pointer: `while (dst < &_ebss) *dst++ = 0;`. When `.bss` is empty, `_sbss` equals `_ebss` and the loop exits immediately. Relying on the emulator zeroing RAM is incorrect: real SRAM is random at power-on. After these two loops, `Reset_Handler` provides exactly what a C runtime startup (crt0) provides.

5.4 Configuring the System Control Block

Steps 5–8 of `Reset_Handler` configure the System Control Block. The meaning of each register and field is described in the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture; this section shows only what the boot code writes and why. All four registers are memory-mapped, so the startup code uses ordinary loads and stores: a plain store when the whole register is written, read-modify-write when other bits must keep their value, and byte stores for the priority bytes.

Step	Register	Operation	Effect
5	`VTOR` (`0xE000ED08`)	`= isr_vector`	exceptions use this table, wherever the image is placed
6	`SHCSR` (`0xE000ED24`)	`|= 0x00070000`	MemManage, BusFault, and UsageFault get their own handlers instead of escalating to HardFault
7	`CCR` (`0xE000ED14`)	`|= 1 << 4`	integer division by zero raises a UsageFault; `STKALIGN` stays 1, so `CCR` becomes `0x210`
8	`SHPR1` – `SHPR3` (`0xE000ED18` …)	byte stores	faults `0x00` , SVCall `0x80` , PendSV and SysTick `0xE0`

`VTOR` is written as a whole word, because all its bits are the table address. `SHCSR` and `CCR` contain status bits or bits that are already set (`STKALIGN`), so they are updated with read-modify-write and never overwritten. Each priority is a separate byte: viewing `SHPR1` – `SHPR3` as a 12-byte array at `0xE000ED18` , the boot code writes indices 0–2 (faults), 7 (SVCall), and 10–11 (PendSV, SysTick).

The effect of steps 6 and 7 is easy to observe with a division by a `volatile` zero. With both settings in place, a C function named `UsageFault_Handler` (which replaces the weak alias) runs and can report `CFSR = 0x2000000` , the `DIVBYZERO` bit. Without the `SHCSR` bits the fault escalates to HardFault and its kind is lost; without `DIV_0_TRP` the division silently returns 0 and `main` continues. The worked example and the fault status bits are in the fault status section of the Cortex-M3 chapter.

5.5 Additional Startup Work on Real Chips

QEMU's CPU runs at full speed out of reset. On a real microcontroller the startup code usually does more, often in a vendor function `SystemInit()` called from `Reset_Handler` :

- **Clock and PLL**: the chip starts on a slow internal oscillator, and a PLL multiplies the frequency up to full speed.
- **Flash wait states**: flash is slower than a fast CPU, so the flash controller must be told to insert wait cycles *before* the clock is raised, or the CPU reads garbage.
- **Watchdog**: a timer that resets the chip unless software periodically feeds it; on some chips it runs from reset, so boot code must feed or disable it.
- **FPU**: on a Cortex-M4F the floating-point unit is off at reset and must be enabled in **CPACR** (`0xE000ED88`), otherwise the first float instruction raises a UsageFault.
- **C++**: static constructors listed in `.init_array` must be called before `main` .

5.6 Verifying Boot State with gdb

A **debugger** controls a running program: it stops it at a breakpoint or before the first instruction, steps it one machine instruction or one C line at a time, inspects and modifies registers and memory, and resumes it. On a microcontroller, where a crash often produces no message at all, it is frequently the only way to see what the CPU does. The ARM build of gdb is `arm-none-eabi-gdb` (`gdb-multiarch` on Linux).

Debugging is **remote**: the program runs inside QEMU, and gdb connects over TCP. QEMU is started with the normal run command plus `-S` (freeze the CPU before its first instruction) and `-gdb tcp::1234` (start a gdb server on port 1234). gdb reads the ELF only for symbols and debug information; QEMU already holds the code.

```
qemu-system-arm -machine mps2-an385 -monitor null -semihosting \
    --semihosting-config enable=on,target=native \
    -kernel build/scratch-os.axf -serial stdio -nographic \
    -S -gdb tcp::1234
```

Command	Effect
`target remote :1234`	connect to the gdb server
`info registers sp pc`	show registers (`info registers` shows all)
`x/2wx 0`	examine 2 words in hex at address 0
`x/s &data_message`	examine memory as a C string
`p/x $r1`	print a register or C expression in hex
`display/i $pc`	show the next instruction after every step
`stepi` (`si`)	execute one machine instruction
`break main` (`b`)	stop when execution reaches a symbol or label
`continue` (`c`)	run to the next breakpoint

Attached before the first instruction, gdb already shows SP = `0x20400000` and PC = `Reset_Handler`, while `x/2wx 0` shows `0x20400000 0x00000041` (or `0x9` with a two-word table): no instruction has executed, so the hardware itself loaded both registers from the vector table, clearing the Thumb bit for PC. At `break main`, the SCB registers hold the values written in steps 5–8 (`VTOR` = `0x00000000`, `CCR` = `0x00000210`, `SHCSR` = `0x00070000`, `SHPR2` = `0x80000000`, `SHPR3` = `0xE0E00000`) and `info registers primask` reads 0 (it reads 0 at reset and 1 after `cpsid i`).

6 Freestanding C and Semihosting

6.1 Hosted and Freestanding Environments

The C standard defines two environments:

Aspect	Hosted	Freestanding
Example	desktop program	bare-metal Cortex-M3 image
Below the program	a C library (libc) and an OS	nothing
`printf`, `malloc`, `fopen`, `exit`	available	not available
Who starts `main()`	libc startup code, invoked by the OS	the application's own startup code

A freestanding environment still provides the headers that need **no run-time code**, only types, constants and macros supplied by the compiler:

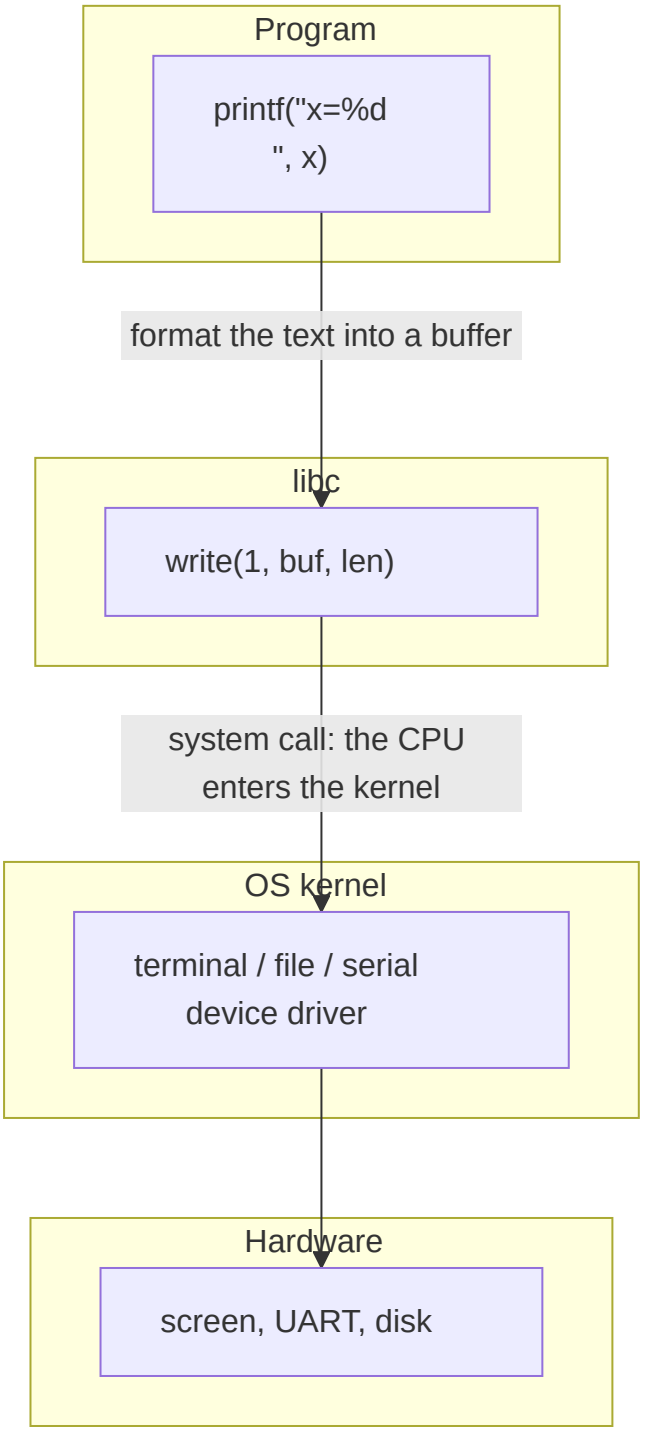
Header	Provides
`stdint.h`	`uint32_t`, `int8_t`, …
`stddef.h`	`size_t`, `NULL`, `offsetof`
`stdbool.h`	`bool`, `true`, `false`
`stdarg.h`	`va_list` for variadic functions
`limits.h`, `float.h`	`INT_MAX`, `FLT_EPSILON`, …

There is no `stdio.h`, `stdlib.h` or `string.h`: no printing, no `malloc`, no `exit`, not even `memcpy`. This is why the boot code copies `.data` with its own loop.

6.2 The Layers Under printf

On a desktop, `printf` looks like a **single function** that writes to the screen. In reality it is the top of a stack of layers, and **most of the work happens in layers that a bare-metal system does not have**:

Figure 3.2 — The layers under printf on a hosted system



`printf` itself only **formats**: it turns `"x=%d"` and `42` into the characters `x=42` in a buffer. **Getting those characters out of the machine** is the **OS's** job, reached through the `write()` system call. Many other libc functions have the same structure: a portable part on top, and a dependency on something underneath.

libc feature	Requires underneath
`printf`, `puts`	`write()`: a way to send bytes to a device

libc feature	Requires underneath
`malloc`, `free`	a heap region, grown with `sbrk()`
`exit`	something to return to
`main()` being called	crt0: sets up stack, `.data`, `.bss`, then calls `main`

6.2.1 libc on Bare Metal

Embedded C libraries such as **newlib** keep the portable part (formatting, string handling, data structures) and leave the bottom functions (`write`, `sbrk`, `exit`, …) as **hooks**: empty stubs that must be implemented for each board.

The firmware described in these notes links **no libc at all**, for three reasons:

Reason	Explanation
Nothing to put under the hooks	there is no kernel, no `write()`, no heap manager yet
crt0 is not needed	`Reset_Handler` already does its work
No hidden code	the image contains only the startup file, the application and a few compiler helpers

> **WHAT REPLACES `PRINTF`**
>
> Without libc, output is produced by the program itself: in this chapter through **semihosting**, and later through a UART driver and the kernel's own `kprintf` / `printf` (see the chapter on devices, interrupts, and system calls).

6.3 Build Flags for a Freestanding Image

```
CFLAGS := -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -nostartfiles -ffreestanding -std=gnu17
LDFLAGS += -nostdlib -lgcc
```

Flag	Meaning
`-ffreestanding`	GCC must not assume a libc or OS exists (e.g. that a function named `printf` behaves like the standard one)
`-nostartfiles`	do not link the toolchain's startup code (crt0)
`-nostdlib`	do not link any standard library or startup file (no `-lc`)
`-lgcc`	add back libgcc, the compiler's own helper routines

`libgcc` is kept because the compiler sometimes turns a plain C operator into a **call** to a helper when the CPU has no single instruction for it. These helpers need neither OS nor libc, and dropping them would make harmless code fail to link.

C code	CPU	GCC emits
`a / b` (32-bit)	Cortex-M0 (no divide instruction)	`bl __aeabi_idiv`
`a / b` (32-bit)	Cortex-M3	`sdiv` (hardware)
`x / y` (64-bit)	Cortex-M3	`bl __aeabi_uldivmod`

Calling `printf` in such a build always fails: with a toolchain that ships no C library, compilation stops with `stdio.h: No such file or directory`; with a toolchain that ships newlib, the header is found but the link fails with `undefined reference to 'printf'` because of `-nostdlib`.

6.4 Semihosting Output via bkpt 0xab

Without libc and without a UART driver, the program has no way of its own to print anything. All the output of the boot code is produced with **semihosting**: the program places `0x04` (`SYS_WRITE0`) in `r0` and the address of a NUL-terminated string in `r1`, then executes `bkpt 0xab`, and the host (QEMU or a debugger) prints the string on its terminal. The convention, the C wrapper `semihost_write0`, and its limits are described in the toolchain chapter.

> **MULTIPLE INSTRUCTIONS IN ONE `__ASM__`**
>
> C concatenates adjacent string literals, so `"ldr r2, [r0]" "ldr r3, [r1]"` reaches the assembler as the single line `ldr r2, [r0]ldr r3, [r1]` and fails with `garbage following instruction`. Each instruction must end with `\n` (commonly `\n\t`) inside the string.

> **SEMIHOSTING IS A TRAP**
>
> The program stops its own work, control passes to a more powerful entity outside the CPU, which performs the job and then returns control. This is exactly the shape of a **system call**, with the host playing the role of the kernel (see the system calls in the chapter on devices, interrupts, and system calls).